Golden Boy

By Clifford Odets

Characters: *Joe: a young Italian man born to immigrant parents in New York*
Lorna: the mistress of Tom Moony, Joe's manager

JOE: *(page 24-25)* I have to tell you— I don't like myself, past, present and future. You don't know what it means to sit around here and watch the months go ticking by! Do you think that's a life for a boy my age? . . . . Nobody takes me serious here! I want to do what I want. I proved it tonight. I'm good — I went out to earn some money and I earned! I had a professional fight tonight — maybe I'll have some more . . . . Tomorrow's my birthday! I'll change my life! Who says I'm married to music? I'll take a vacation — the notes won't run away!

INTRODUCTION

ACTRESS: *(Throughout the introduction, we see Joe in the background, alternating between shadow boxing and pantomiming the playing of a violin) That's Joe. He's the Golden Boy . . . struggling to choose between his violin and a pair of boxing gloves. Boxing could be his ticket to riches, fame and recognition – his path out of the Great Depression to the American Dream. But at what personal cost? His rise to stardom is dimmed by his sub-conscious need to protect his hands. He wins on points, not knockouts. He's just not aggressive enough to be a star . . .*

And then Lorna, his manager's mistress, intervenes. Her assigned goal: to convince Joe to do what he needs to do to become a prize-fighter. Her personal goal: to explore her growing feelings for a young, confused man. Golden Boy by Clifford Odets

LORNA: *(page 34-39)* Success and fame! Or just a lousy living. You're lucky you won't have to worry about those things. . . .

JOE: Won't I? . . . Where's Mr. Moody tonight?

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LORNA: He goes up to see his kid on Tuesday nights. It's a sick kid, a girl. His wife leaves it at her mother's house. *(changing the topic)* [Your trainer] says you're going far in the fighting game.

JOE: Music means more to me. Playing music . . . that's like saying, "I am man. I belong here. How do you do, World— good evening!" When I play music I'm not afraid of people and what they say. There's no war in music. I might give up fighting as a bad job. I'm not over-convinced it's what I want. I can do other things. . . . You have to be what you are—!

LORNA: Fight! See what happens— who says you have to be one thing?

JOE: My nature isn't fighting!

LORNA: Joe, listen: be a fighter! Show the world! If you made your fame and fortune— and you can— you'd be anything you want. Do it! Bang your way to the lightweight crown. . . You're too inside yourself. That's right— "me, myself, and I." Why not come out and see the world?

JOE: Does it seem that way? *(a beat while Joe considers his options . . . ultimately the lure of boxing wins out)* If you're vitally interested in my future, prove it! Get me some fights— fights with contenders, not with dumb-bunny club fighters. And how about some mention in the press? Twenty-six bouts — no one knows I'm alive. Match me up against real talent.

LORNA: You're a miserable creature. You'll take fame so people won't laugh or scorn your face. You'd give your soul for those things. But every time you turn your back [on your music] your little soul kicks you in the teeth. It don't give in so easy.

JOE: *(in retaliation for Lorna's insight – angrily)* [Oh, yeah?} This is the anatomy of Lorna Moon: she's a lost baby. She doesn't know what's right or wrong. She's a miserable creature who never knew what to pick. But she'd never admit it. And I'll tell you why you picked Moody!

LORNA: You don't know what you're talking about.

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JOE: Go home, Lorna. If you stay, I'll know something about you. . . . Now's your chance— go home!

LORNA: Tom loves me.

JOE: *(after a long silence, looking ahead – it's clear that Joe has feelings for Lorna and that she is battling her feelings for him as well. Joe changes the subject again)* I'm going to buy a car. I saw it in the paper, but it costs too much— fourteen thousand. If I found one second hand—

LORNA: And if you had the cash— [you would] if you'd go in and really fight!

JOE: *(in a sudden burst)* Tell your Mr. Moody I'll dazzle the eyes out of his head!

LORNA: You mean it?

JOE: *(looking out ahead)* Those cars are poison in my blood. When you sit in a car and speed you're looking down at the world. Speed, speed, everything is speed— *(standing up suddenly and miming a quick uppercut)* I'll walk you back to your house— your hotel, I mean. *(Lorna stands. Joe continues.)* When you're lying in his arms tonight, tell him, for me, that the next world's champ is feeding in his stable.

TRANSITION

ACTRESS: *(during this transition, we see Joe in the background massaging his hand in in despair as he realizes that he will never again be able to play the violin) Despite her growing feelings for Joe, Lorna feels unable to break it off with Moody. Feeling as though he has sold his soul to the devil and realizing that Lorna may be beyond his reach . . . Joe no longer holds back in the ring. Months pass and Joe becomes more and more aggressive . . . violent . . . successful. But with each victory he loses a little of himself . . . When one bout results in a broken hand, he seeks the solace of Lorna once again.*

JOE: *(page 53 – 57)* Some nights I wake up— my heart's beating a mile a minute! Before I open my eyes I know what it is— the feeling that someone's standing at my bed. Then I open my eyes . . . it's gone— ran away!

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LORNA: Maybe it's that old fiddle of yours. Do you ever think of it any more— music?

JOE: What're you trying to remind me of? A kid with a Buster Brown collar and a violin case tucked under his arm? Does that sound appetizing to you?

LORNA: Not when you say it that way. You said it different once. . . . What's on [your mind]?

JOE: *(simply)* You. . . . You're real for me— the way music was real.

LORNA: You've got your car, your career— what do you want with me?

JOE: I develop the ability to knock down anyone my weight. But what point have I made? Don't you think I know that?. . . . I'm not sure I like it.

LORNA: Moody's against that car of yours.

JOE: I'm against Moody, so we're even. He's a manager! He treats me like a possession! I'm just a little silver mine for him— he bangs me around with a shovel!

LORNA: He's helped you—

JOE: No, [my trainer's] helped me. Why don't you give him up? Why don't you belong to me? Why don't you teach me love? . . . Or am I being a fool?

LORNA: You're not a fool, Joe.

JOE: I want you to be my family, my life— Why don't you do it, Lorna, why?

LORNA: He loves me.

JOE: I love you!

LORNA: *(treading delicately)* I can't give him anguish. I . . . I know what it's like. He's poor compared to you. You're alive, you've got yourself— I can't feel sorry for you!

JOE: But you don't love him! You feel close to me. But you're afraid—

LORNA: Of what?

JOE: To take a chance! I feel it all the time— you're half dead, and you don't know it!

LORNA: *(evasively)* Why start what we can't finish?

JOE: *(fiercely)* Oh, Lorna, deep as my voice will reach— listen! Why can't you leave him? Why?

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LORNA: Because he needs me and you don't—

JOE: That's not true!

LORNA: Because he's a desperate guy who always starts out with two strikes against him. Because he's a kid at forty-two and you're a man at twenty-two.

JOE: You're sorry for him? What did he ever do for you?

LORNA: *(with sudden verve)* Would you like to know? He loved me in a world of enemies . . . and I loved him for that. He picked me up in Friskin's hotel on 39th Street. I was nine weeks behind in rent. I hadn't hit the gutter yet, but I was near. He washed my face and combed my hair. He stiffened the space between my shoulder blades. Misery reached out to misery—

JOE: And now you're dead.

LORNA: *(lashing out)* I don't know what the hell you're talking about!

JOE: Yes, you do. . . .

LORNA: *(withdrawing - There is silence)* You make me feel too human, Joe. All I want is peace and quiet, not love. I'm a tired, Joe, and I don't mind being what you call "half dead." In fact it's what I like. *(Her voice mounting higher - now half crying.)* Joe. I beg you . . . let me alone. . . . *(She cries softly. Joe reaches out and takes her hand; he gives her a handkerchief which she uses. Lorna, finally.)* That's the third time I cried in my life. . . .

JOE: Now I know you love me. . . I'll tell Moody.

LORNA: Not yet. Maybe he'd kill you if he knew.

JOE: Maybe.

LORNA: I'll tell him. . . .

JOE: When?

LORNA: Not tonight. . . He went up there tonight with six hundred bucks to bribe her into divorce. *(sadly)* He's a good guy, neat all over— sweet. I'll tell him tomorrow.

JOE: *(standing and facing her)* Lorna, when I talk to you . . . something moves in my heart.

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LORNA: But how do I know you love me? How do I know it's true? You'll get to be the champ. They'll all want you, all the girls! I feel like a tramp. I've felt like a tramp for years. *(pg 61)* It has to end. . . . *(it's unclear whether Lorna is referring to her relationship with Moody or with Joe)*

TRANSITION

ACTOR: *Time again passes and Lorna begins to avoid Joe . . . he soon discovers why. Moody has divorced his wife and he and Lorna have plans to be married . . . soon. After months of silence and outright avoidance, Joe's path crosses Lorna's once again, in the hallway of the training center on the eve of his largest fight to date – a battle against the Champion, the "Baltimore Chocolate Drop."*

(On his way to the ring, Joe sees Lorna in the hallway. Her back is turned and it is clear that the desire to speak to her is at war with his desire to turn and walk away . . . his need to speak wins out)

JOE: *(pg 79 – 80)* I hear you're making the leap tomorrow. • • •

LORNA: Sunday . . .

JOE: Sunday. *(Intense silence - finally)* Congratulations. . . .

LORNA: *(without turning)* Thanks. . . . *(In a sudden irresistible surge Joe lashes out)*

JOE: When I speak to you, look at me!

LORNA: What would you like to say? *(They stand face to face, straining.)*

JOE: *(finally)* Marry anyone you like!

LORNA: Thanks for permission!

JOE: Queen Lorna, the tramp of Newark!

LORNA: You haven't spoken to me for months. Why break your silence?

JOE: You're a historical character for me— dead and buried!

LORNA: Then everything's simple; go about your business.

JOE: Moody's right for you— perfect— the mating of zero and zero!

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LORNA: I'm not sorry to marry Tom—

JOE: *(scornfully)* That's from the etiquette book— page twelve: "When you marry a man say you like it!"

LORNA: I know I could do worse when I look at you. When did you look in the mirror last? Getting to be a killer! You're not the boy I cared about, not you. You murdered that boy with the generous face- God knows where you hid the bodyl I don't know you.

TRANSITION

ACTOR: *Disoriented by their argument, Joe goes into the ring and can't stay focused.*
ACTRESS: *He is down until the eighth round but pulls through with a victory at the last moment.*
ACTOR: *Before the celebration gets underway Joe is alerted that his final blow to the "Chocolate Drop" has killed the boxer.*

(In the training room, Joe is stunned by his own violence – he paces frantically muttering to himself – Lorna enters)

LORNA: *(pg 87 – 88)* Joe . . . it wasn't your fault.

JOE: That's right— it wasn't my fault! I wouldn't want to do that, would I? Everybody knows I wouldn't want to kill a man. Lorna, you know it!

LORNA: Of course!

JOE: But I did it! That's the thing-I did it! What will my father say when he hears I murdered a man? Lorna, I see what I did. I murdered myself, too! I've been running around in circles. That's the truth. Yes, I was a real sparrow, and I wanted to be a fake eagle! But now I'm hung up by my fingertips— I'm no good!

LORNA: (in a sudden burst, going to Joe): Joe . . . You wanted to conquer the world— But it's not the kings and dictators who do it— it's that kid in the park—

JOE: Yes, that boy who might have said, "I have myself; I am what I want to be!"

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LORNA: And now, tonight, here, this minute— [you found] yourself again— that's what makes you a champ. Don't you see that? Give up the fighting business!

JOE: Tonight!

LORNA: Yes, and go back to your music—

JOE: But my hands are ruined. I'll never play again! What's left, Lorna? Half a man, nothing, useless . . .

LORNA: No, we're left! Two together! We have each other! (quietly) I love you. Somewhere there must be happy boys and girls who can teach us the way of life! Well find some city where poverty's no shame— where music is no crime!— where there's no war in the streets— where a man is glad to be himself, to live and make his woman herself!

JOE: No more fighting, but where do we go?

LORNA: Tonight? Joe, we ride in your car. We speed through the night, across the park, over the Triboro Bridge—

JOE: *(taking Lorna's arms in his trembling hands)* Ride! That's it, we ride— clear my head. We'll drive through the night. When you mow down the night with headlights, nobody gets you! You're on top of the world then *(long beat)* [and] nobody laughs!

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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